

Blind and Low Vision with Complex Needs

iPad tools • AAC • tactile supports • everyday participation

Start with the person: communication goals, usable senses, movement, interests, language, and daily environments. Combine tools as needed. These are options to trial, not a developmental ladder.

01 Access to the iPad

BUILT-IN FEATURES

- VoiceOver: spoken navigation; compatible braille displays.
- Zoom and display settings: adjust size, contrast, and color.
- Switch Control and Touch Accommodations: trial motor access.

Test the person’s actual device, app, and access method. [1]

02 Tactile & object communication

NO-TECH / LOW-TECH

- Real objects, object cues, and personally meaningful tactile symbols.
- APH Tactile Connections and STACS: tactile communication resources.
- Pair symbols with lived experiences and consistent partner responses.

For deafblind users, individualize tactile and hearing access. [2-4]

03 Auditory AAC & scanning

DOCUMENTED APP FEATURES

- Proloquo2Go: auditory cues with scanning or First Finger Down access.
- TD Snap Scanning: auditory feedback within its scanning page set.
- Partner-assisted scanning: present choices; honor an agreed response.

Hearing access, scan pace, cue language, and fatigue matter. [5-7]

04 AAC using available vision

INDIVIDUALIZED VISUAL ACCESS

- Trial symbol-based AAC only when symbols and navigation are accessible.
- Individualize spacing, contrast, size, lighting, and positioning.
- For CVI, assess visual complexity and offer auditory or tactile access.

Speech output alone does not make a visual AAC system accessible. [4,7]

05 Text, braille & speech

DOCUMENTED APP / SYSTEM FEATURES

- Proloquo4Text: text AAC with documented VoiceOver and Switch Control support.
- Apple Live Speech: speaks typed text and saved phrases.
- VoiceOver + compatible braille: trial reading, entry, and navigation.

Text AAC is one option; literacy is not a prerequisite for AAC. [1,8,9]

06 Routines & sensory support

EVERYDAY PARTICIPATION

- Use tactile calendars, object schedules, or accessible spoken reminders.
- Provide language for breaks, discomfort, changes, and asking for help.
- Keep communication available during fatigue, stress, and transitions.

A schedule supports understanding; it does not replace a voice.

07 Stories, literacy & connection

SHARED EXPERIENCES

- Combine real experiences with tactile story objects and accessible books.
- Model language through the person’s usable sensory channels.
- Include names, humor, questions, opinions, and social conversation.

Support literacy alongside AAC; offer age-respectful content.

08 Choice, consent & self-advocacy

COMMUNICATION ON THE PERSON’S TERMS

- Ensure access to “no,” “stop,” “different,” “help,” and “I have more to say.”
- Allow time; confirm meaning without choosing the message for the person.
- Keep a usable backup: tactile symbols, a board, or partner-assisted scanning.

Expand language beyond requesting and answering adult questions.

Trial together: the person + family/caregivers + TVI + SLP/AAC specialist + OT/AT; include deafblind expertise when relevant. Check access to every function, meaningful expression, effort, reliability, and support needed across settings.

AAC = augmentative and alternative communication. TVI = teacher of students with visual impairments. CVI = cerebral/cortical visual impairment. Sources [1-9] and screen-reader text are in the companion HTML file.

Sources & trial notes

Features checked October 6, 2026 against publisher documentation; not independently tested. App features are specific to the named product or page set. Confirm current device requirements, costs, and access before purchase. Eye tracking requires individual assessment; it is not a default solution for vision loss.

[1] Apple — accessibility features

<https://www.apple.com/accessibility/features/>

[2] APH — Tactile Connections

<https://www.aph.org/product/tactile-connections-symbols-for-communication/>

[3] APH — STACS

<https://www.aph.org/product/stacs-standardized-tactile-augmentative-communication-symbols/>

[4] APH ConnectCenter — symbol systems

<https://aphconnectcenter.org/familyconnect/education/ecc/social-interaction-skills/symbol-systems/>

[5] AssistiveWare — Proloquo2Go auditory cues

<https://www.assistiveware.com/support/proloquo2go/alternative-access/get-auditory-cues>

[6] Tobii Dynavox — TD Snap Scanning

<https://us.tobiidynavox.com/pages/td-snap-scanning>

[7] Perkins — CVI, complex communication needs, and AAC

<https://www.perkins.org/resource/what-do-you-need-to-know-about-cvi-complex-communication-needs-and-aac-systems/>

[8] AssistiveWare — Proloquo4Text

<https://www.assistiveware.com/products/proloquo4text>

[9] Apple — Live Speech on iPad

<https://support.apple.com/guide/ipad/type-to-speak-ipad32ad5293/ipados>

Suggested trial record

- What does the person want to communicate, and with whom?
- How do they find, select, edit, cancel, and speak or share a message?
- Which sensory and motor access methods work in familiar and unfamiliar places?
- How do fatigue, positioning, lighting, noise, and partner support affect access?
- What backup works when the device, app, hearing, or usable vision is unavailable?